Arthur Belfer was so good at selling down feathers that he won the United States Army contract to supply down sleeping bags to the military during the Korean War. He expanded into foam rubber, and then in 1953 founded the Belco Petroleum Corporation. His son Robert joined the company in 1958.[250]

Belco Petroleum grew rapidly over the next decade. In 1962, it became a Fortune 500 company, and soon after, Belco Petroleum went public on the NYSE. Arthur's son Robert was named president in 1965.

The firm continued to grow. With the price of oil rising in the 1970s and 1980s, Robert successfully navigated the firm through several M&A transactions. In 1983, Belco merged with InterNorth Inc., forming BelNorth Petroleum Corporation. Two years later, InterNorth (including its BelCo assets) merged with Houston Natural Gas Corporation.

The Belfer family had become wealthy as their stock compounded over the decades. By 1993, when Arthur Belfer passed away at 86, he had quietly become a billionaire.

That 1985 merger would prove fateful: If the name "Houston Natural Gas Corporation" sounds somewhat familiar, perhaps you might recognize it by its modern name: **Enron Corporation**.

We think of Enron today as a debacle that went bankrupt in 2001 due to its accounting fraud. But for much of the 15 years prior, it was a fast-growing natural gas and commodities firm.

Robert Belfer sat on its board of directors for much of that period. He had graduated Columbia with a bachelor's degree before getting his JD at Harvard Law School. Despite his education, he was just as bamboozled by the bullshit Enron's founder, chairman, and CEO Ken Lay and President Jeff Skilling was spreading as the rest of us.[251]

The *New York Times* reported, "In a disaster the size of the Enron collapse, it can be hard to choose the biggest loser, but a leading candidate has to be